Coimisiún na Scrúduithe Stáit
State Examinations Commission

LEAVING CERTIFICATE EXAMINATION

English - Higher Level - Paper 1

Total Marks: 140

Duration: 2 hours 50 minutes

- This paper is divided into two sections,
  Section I COMPREHENDING and Section II COMPOSING.
- The paper contains **three** texts on the general theme of **IRISH WRITERS**.
- Candidates should familiarise themselves with each of the texts before beginning their answers.
- Both sections of this paper (COMPREHENDING and COMPOSING) must be attempted.
- Section I, Comprehending, carries 40 marks.
- Section II, Composing, carries 100 marks.

SECTION I – COMPREHENDING

- Two Questions, A and B, follow each text.
- Candidates must answer **ONE** question in Section I:
  either one Question A **OR one** Question B on **ONE** text.

SECTION II – COMPOSING

- Candidates must write on **one** of the compositions 1 – 7.

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SECTION I COMPREHENDING (40 marks)

TEXT 1 – CIARAN CARTY MEETS PAULA MEEHAN

This edited text is adapted from an interview conducted with poet, Paula Meehan. It appears in Ciaran Carty's collection of interviews entitled, *Writer to Writer, The Republic of Elsewhere*.

It's more than 40 years, and many books, since Paula Meehan emerged from childhood in the inner-city Dublin tenements to give voice to the disenfranchised everywhere. She does this less in anger than with compassion and an intuitive understanding that, through verse, she imbues their lives and memories with mythic dignity. Eavan Boland marvelled at Meehan's "wonderful zest and warmth of tone", noting that her "themes are daring and open up new areas for her own work as well as for contemporary Irish poetry". To English poet Carol Ann Duffy she is "that rare and precious thing – a vocational poet of courage and integrity".

Born in 1955, she was brought up by her grandparents while her parents were looking for work in England. "We lived on the corner of Sean McDermott Street and Gardiner Street, which is gone now. My childhood city is practically obliterated, the last coherent community in the North inner city. The people had nothing, but they had a sense of sharing. I grew up in an oral tradition. I got my language there. I'm not nostalgic for the poverty, but the attempt to alleviate those terrible living conditions led to much displacement and breaking apart of the community."

Paula lives in Baldoyle with poet and broadcaster Theo Dorgan, whose childhood in Cork in many ways parallels her own. "I'm the eldest from a family of six, he's the eldest of fifteen. He had to take responsibility from an early age. There's something fearless about him. He understands people and sees something in everyone, yet at the same time knows when to remain detached."

Paula's grandfather taught her to read and write. "Without that I don't know how I'd have survived school. Underlying everything was a sense that girls didn't need an education. We were learning the skills for young girls to go into service or factories. So being able to read and write from the start was like a weapon. It gave me independence."

She moved to Finglas as a teenager. "There were bands everywhere. Music was a great unifying culture. We were the first global generation. We felt connected with what was happening in the world. Thanks to O'Malley's free education scheme, we were now allowed to go to secondary school and university."

The nuns at St Michael's Holy Faith Convent didn't know what had hit them. "I was not compliant. So I didn't last long. We were absorbing the language of protest and reading about revolutions. I led a protest. So they threw me out. Looking back, I've a lot of sympathy for them having to put up with us. It must have been a culture shock for them. But for us it was a sense that we had a right to education."

After her Leaving Certificate, Paula studied at Trinity College. "I wasn't a good student. I just did the things I wanted to do. The poet Eiléan Ní Chuilleanáin taught me etymology, the history of words and sounds. I'd scribbled poems since I was at school, inspired by music and songs. But I didn't have confidence in my writing. It was a very male milieu. I became a secret writer."

She dropped out for a year, hitching to Crete, "to walk in the landscape that gave rise to the ancient myths". This sense of the past in the present, the living myth embedded in landscape, fed into her poetry. A scholarship brought her to America to study for a master's degree in creative writing. "The North West was a vital place for poetry. Looking back through the stories of the indigenous population gave me a new take on our own early culture, which was also full of stories and songs about hunting and fishing."

Her first collection, *Return and No Blame*, was published in 1984. Although it caught the attention of Eavan Boland, it didn't pay any bills. As the 1980s recession deepened, Paula moved to Leitrim, living on social welfare. Some of her poems were published in a Sunday newspaper. It gave her the confidence to write her long breakthrough poem, "The Statue of the Virgin at Granard Speaks". The playwright, Tom Murphy, wrote her a wonderful letter which she read and read until it was in shreds. "That galvanised me. I thought, I'm going to stand up for the word."

Poetry can be many things to many people. Award-winning English writer, Jeanette Winterson, has called it "a shot of espresso, a rope in a storm, a conversation across time". Paula likens making a poem to a child at a window making a mark with her breath. "It's something we've all done, and I still do."

N.B. Answer only ONE question in Section I, either one Question A OR one Question B on one text.

QUESTION A – 40 Marks

(i) Based on your reading of TEXT 1, explain three insights you gain into the influences that may have helped Paula Meehan to develop as a writer. Support your answer with reference to the text. (10)

(ii) Jeanette Winterson and Paula Meehan make a variety of observations about poetry in the final paragraph of TEXT 1. To what extent can you relate these writers' observations to your experience of poetry? Explain your response. (10)

(iii) Identify four elements of the writer's style, evident in the edited interview above, and discuss how these stylistic elements make the piece a positive and revealing portrait of Paula Meehan. Support your answer with reference to the text. (20)

QUESTION B – 40 Marks

In TEXT 1, Paula Meehan speaks about how her poetry was inspired by music and songs. Write **an open letter**, to be published on a popular social media platform, in which you argue for or against the inclusion of song lyrics in the selection of poetry prescribed for the Leaving Certificate English course. In your open letter you should: explain your position in relation to the inclusion of song lyrics as poetry on the English course, seek to anticipate and refute views that might potentially be offered in opposition to your chosen stance and illustrate your argument with reference to at least one poem and the lyrics of at least one song.

TEXT 2 – BILLY O'CALLAGHAN

This text is adapted from Billy O'Callaghan's essay, *The Nature of Stories*. The essay appears in a collection of essays entitled, *The Danger and the Glory, Irish Authors on the Art of Writing*.

In July of 2016, I was in China, travelling by train from Beijing back to Shanghai after a couple of weeks spent exploring some of the northern part of that ridiculously vast country. Still an hour or so out of Shanghai, we crossed a small, dull thread of river. I'd been watching the passing landscape and keeping check on the horizon, hoping that the sea would come into view.

The river had nothing much about it to speak of, except for a little wooden boat, some six or eight feet of scrap lumber nailed to create a high-sided trough, but in the few seconds that it took to pass in and out of my field of vision an entire story fell on me.

I can remember the sensation, the breathlessness of the moment, as if it had been just waiting there for me to pass. I felt at the same time knocked stupid and heightened. I suppose because of the soothing tranquility of the train, I'd been day-dreaming, and thinking a dozen or a thousand thoughts at once; but in that instant, something about the sight of the river, the boat, or maybe the thin yellow-white fall of the light on the water, bound all my strands of thought, conscious and otherwise, together in a particular and specific way, much as how I imagine stars are formed.

I had a notebook in my backpack and struggled to keep up with how fast the story came. I kept getting in the way of it and had to cross out words and whole sentences. At the station in Shanghai, I got off the train and transferred to the subway, hitting the rush hour crowds so that the carriage I boarded was packed almost beyond breathing space. I kept scribbling, stooped down and using the bodies around me for balance. By Heathrow, some fifteen or twenty hours on from that first moment in the train and nearly fit to drop, the story was done, the essential rags of it, anyway, which would be stitched together over the following couple of weeks, the edges trimmed and seams defined.

With neither intent nor expectation, I'd written a new story called, 'The Boatman'. The links within the final text to China, or to that river boat, were almost non-existent, yet something in what I'd seen or felt in that moment on the train helped prompt a deeper and more personal story into being. The finished story, fictional though it was, seemed so much a part of me that I refuse even now to believe it hadn't been smouldering away inside me always, biding its time, waiting to be told. But I also have to wonder, if I'd not been on that particular train in that far corner of the world at that precise second, whether the story would still have been written, or written differently. Would it have been lost to me, and maybe picked up by somebody else, to be slanted the way they needed to see it?

In the manner of its arrival, 'The Boatman' was very much an anomaly, and while my life would be so much easier if all the stories I want to write could drop into the world so complete and with such speed and assurance,

it also doesn't matter that the opposite is far closer to my reality. The truth is, I'm not necessarily chasing easy, and I seem to get as much from the actual forging of the work, the struggle of getting it into a shape I want and need it to be, as I do from its completion. Once a story has gone as far as I can take it, there's a feeling of relief and, I suppose of accomplishment. But it doesn't last and probably shouldn't. Because there are so many more stories to tell.

If my stories are at all a reflection of who I am – and I can't help but feel that my better ones are – then it is probably correct that they should come slowly and without certainty, that every sentence needs to be wrestled into place. I am not writing autobiography, except in the sense that what comes out, when it comes out well, speaks of how I see the world, and also my place in it, however peripheral that might be. What I hope for, and strive for, is something that reads as truthful, even if it doesn't always match the facts.

Where the stories themselves come from, is, I'm afraid, imprecise. My starting point generally seems to be with theme. The elements of life that most trouble or haunt me start to coalesce. Some make themselves apparent over a long stretch of time; a few – rootedness and exile, isolation, love and its absence, loneliness, time's passing, guilt and the ability to endure – feel permanent. And it's from this slow fog, largely, that stories emerge, vaguely tormenting, looking to be explained, or made sense of.

Language excites me, the way it can layer meanings into itself, even seemingly in its most simple state, and how it feels 'off' if it should be forced to carry a syllable too many. Words are old magic, and the best stories, poems and novels cast spells and crack eternity and let the light come streaming in. On good days the sentences sing to me in the stillness and I glow with them.

N.B. Answer only ONE question in Section I, either one Question A OR one Question B on one text.

QUESTION A – 40 Marks

(i) Based on your reading of TEXT 2, explain three insights you gain into Billy O'Callaghan's creative writing process. Support your answer with reference to the text. (10)

(ii) In the above essay, Billy O'Callaghan expresses the view that, "the best stories, poems and novels cast spells and crack eternity and let the light come streaming in." To what extent can you relate this observation to your experience of literature? Explain your response. (10)

(iii) Identify four elements of the writer's style, evident in the edited essay above, and discuss how these stylistic elements make the essay an intimate and attractive piece of writing. Support your answer with reference to the text. (20)

QUESTION B – 40 Marks

In TEXT 2, Billy O'Callaghan refers to his travels in China. You have been invited to contribute to a podcast series of travel documentaries. Write **the text for the podcast** in which you: celebrate the many and varied delights of travelling both near and far, reflect on the pleasure you derive from planning possible future trips and explain the reasons why you like to keep a journal when you travel.

TEXT 3 – MAGGIE O'FARRELL

The following text is based on edited extracts from Maggie O'Farrell's novel, *Hamnet*. In this extract, Shakespeare is about to go on stage, playing the role of the ghost in his play, *Hamlet*.

He [Shakespeare] is standing just behind the musicians' gallery, at a small opening that gives out over the whole theatre. The other actors know this habit of his and never store their costumes or props there, never take up the space around that window.

They think he stands there to watch the people as they arrive. They believe he likes to assess how many are coming, how big the audience will be, how much the takings.

But that is not why. To him, it is the best place to be, before a performance: the stage below him, the audience filling the circular hollow in a steady trickle, and the other players behind him, transforming themselves from men to sprites or princes or soldiers or ladies or monsters. It is the only place to be alone in such a crowd. He feels like a bird, above the ground, resting on nothing but air. He is not of this place but above it, apart from it, observing it. It brings to mind, for him, the wind-hovering kestrel his wife used to keep, and the way it would hold itself in high currents, far above the tree tops, wings outstretched, looking down on all around it.

Beneath him, far beneath him, people are gathering. He can hear their calls, their murmurings, the shouts, the greetings, demands for nuts or sweetmeats, arguments that brew up quickly, then die away.

From behind him comes a crash, a curse, a burst of laughter. Someone has tripped on someone else's feet. There is a ribald joke about falling. More laughter. Someone else comes running up the stairs, asking, "Has anyone seen my sword, I've lost my sword, which of you dogs has taken it?".

Soon, he will need to disrobe, to take off

the clothes of daily life, of the street, of ordinariness, and put on his costume. He will need to confront his image in a glass and make it into something else. He will take a paste of chalk and lime and spread it over his cheeks, his nose, his beard. Charcoal to darken the eye sockets and the brows. Armour to strap to his chest, a helmet to slot over his head, a burial sheet to place about his shoulders. And then he will wait, listening, following the lines, until he hears his cue, and then he will step out, into the light, to inhabit the form of another; he will inhale; he will say his words.

He cannot tell, as he stands there, whether or not this new play is good. Sometimes, as he listens to his company speak the lines, he thinks he has come close to what he wanted it to be; other times, he feels he has entirely missed the mark. It is good, it is bad, it is somewhere in between. How does a person ever tell? All he can do is inscribe strokes on a page – for weeks and weeks, this was all he did, barely leaving his room, barely eating, never speaking to anyone else. The play, the complete length of it fills his head. It balances there, like a laden platter on a single fingertip.

The river is casting its frail net of mist. He can scent it on the breeze, its dank and weed-filled fumes wafting towards him. Perhaps it is this fog, this river-heavy air, he doesn't know, but the day feels ill to him. He is filled with an unease, a slight foreboding, as if something is coming for him. Is it the performance? Does he feel something will be amiss with it? He frowns, thinking, running over in his head any moments that might feel un-rehearsed or ill-prepared. There is not one. He knows this because he himself pushed them through it, over and over again.

The playhouse is a round wooden place with a stage jutting out into the gathering crowd, and above them all, a ceiling of sky, a circle containing fast-moving clouds. More and more people are pouring through the doors. Some on the ground are gesturing and shouting to others in the higher balconies. A group in the highest tier is making much of the lowering of a length of rope. There is shouting and laughter. A man selling pies ties to its end a laden basket and the people above begin to haul it up. Several members of the crowd leap to snatch it; the pie-man deals each of them a swift, cracking blow. A coin is thrown down by the people above and the pie-man lunges to catch it. One of the men he has just hit gets to it first and the pie-man grabs him around the throat; the man lands a punch on the pie-man's chin. They go down, hard, swallowed by the crowd amid much cheering and noise.

Trumpets sound, a hush falls over the crowd and two men walk on to the stage. No one speaks. No one moves. Everyone is entirely focused on these actors and what they are saying. Gone is the jostling, whistling, brawling, pie-chewing mass and in its place a silent, awed congregation. It is as if a magician or sorcerer has waved his staff over the place and turned them all to stone.

N.B. Answer only ONE question in Section I, either one Question A OR one Question B on one text.

QUESTION A – 40 Marks

(i) Based on your reading of TEXT 3, explain three insights you gain into the theatrical world at the time in which the novel is set. Support your answer with reference to the text. (10)

(ii) In the final paragraph of TEXT 3, we witness the power of a dramatic performance to transform a raucous crowd into "a silent, awed congregation". To what extent can you relate the experience of the audience in the text to your experience at concerts, matches, dramatic productions or other live performances? Explain your answer. (10)

(iii) Identify four features of the language of narration, evident in TEXT 3, and discuss how effectively these features are employed to craft a dramatic and revealing portrait of Shakespeare prior to the first performance of his new play, *Hamlet*. Support your answer with reference to the text. (20)

QUESTION B – 40 Marks

After a break of several years, your school Principal wants to revive the school's long-established tradition of staging an annual musical production. As a member of the Student Council, you have agreed to give **a talk** at a school assembly in which you: promote the revival of this school tradition, remind the school community of the success of some of the previous productions and encourage members of the school community to become involved in the various roles and tasks associated with the production. Write the text of the talk you would deliver.

SECTION II COMPOSING (100 marks)

Write a composition on **any one** of the assignments that appear in **bold print** below.

Each composition carries 100 marks.

The composition assignments are intended to reflect language study in the areas of information, argument, persuasion, narration, and the aesthetic use of language.

1. TEXT 3 is set in a theatre, a place filled with drama and dramatic characters.

Write a personal essay in which you reflect on how dull your life would be without those colourful people who occasionally add drama and excitement. In your essay you may refer both to people whom you know and to celebrities.

2. In TEXT 2, we learn how Billy O'Callaghan was inspired to write his story, 'The Boatman', having seen a little wooden boat on a river in China.

Write a short story, set in China in the past or in the present, in which a river boatman in a small craft plays an important part.

3. In TEXT 1, Paula Meehan talks about being part of the first "global generation".

Write an article to be published in an online journal, on what it means to be part of a "global generation".

4. In TEXT 3, Shakespeare is filled with a sense of unease and foreboding before the play begins.

Write a short story, set in Shakespeare's Globe Theatre on the day described in Text 3. Your story should include an event that fulfils Shakespeare's premonition of trouble.

5. In TEXT 2, the writer states that, "on good days the sentences sing to me in the stillness and I glow with them."

Write a personal essay in which you reflect on what makes you "glow" with joy or satisfaction.

6. In TEXT 1, Paula Meehan observes that, "… being able to read and write from the start was like a weapon".

Write a speech, to be delivered to an international conference on education for young people, about the skills and knowledge that you think young people need to flourish in the twenty-first century.

7. In TEXT 1, we learn about Paula Meehan's rebellious youth and her independent personality.

Write a discursive essay on the importance of independent thinking and the role of rebels in society.

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Acknowledgements

Images and texts that appear on this examination paper were sourced as follows:

TEXT 1: Carty, C., *Writer to Writer, The Republic of Elsewhere*, The Lilliput Press, Dublin, 2018.
Image: www.irishtimes.con/culture/paula-meehan-the-poet-at-60-1.2115401 photo: Dave Meehan

TEXT 2: Schwall, H. (Ed.), *The Danger and the Glory,* Irish writers on the Art of Writing, Arlen House, Dublin, 2019.
Image: https://upload.wikimedia.org/wikipedia/commons/thumb/a/aa/Unknown_%28Chinese%29_-_Boat_with_Three_Boatmen_-_56.147_-_Detroit_Institute_of_Arts.jpg/1280px-Unknown_%28Chinese%29_-_Boat_with_Three_Boatmen_-_56.147_-_Detroit_Institute_of_Arts.jpg

TEXT 3: O'Farrell M., *Hamnet,* Tinder Press, London, 2020.
Image: https://www.shakespearesglobe.com/discover/blogs-and-features/2017/06/12/building-shakespeares-globe/
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Leaving Certificate – Higher Level

English

2 hours 50 minutes